

Inside the EU's crisis room

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POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By GERARDO FORTUNA CIAO T

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CIAO THERE. It's Gerardo Fortuna in your inboxes one last time before taking a breather. This newsletter is in safe hands, though: my ace teammate Sebastian Starcevic will be steering Playbook next week.

START HERE: Ceuta is once again a flashpoint in Europe's migration fight after thousands of migrants reached the Spanish enclave from Morocco, with at least 18 dying in the attempt, according to the latest reports overnight. Spain is deploying its military to restore order at the border and the EU's Migration Commissioner Magnus Brunner said Brussels is offering support through Frontex .

Italy is seizing on the crisis to argue that Spain should be suspended from Schengen . PM Giorgia Meloni says Rome is prepared to take "extraordinary measures" to protect its borders. Expect the political fallout to spread today.

In today's Playbook:

— The European Commission's new special representative for Cyprus begins his first mission on shaky ground.

— FIFA needs better rules, not more money, to protect the World Cup, says the Council of Europe.

— Faces in the crowd: Glenn Micallef, Nikos Christodoulides, J.K. Rowling, Borja Miguelez, Raffaele Fitto, Sepp Blatter, Maria Zuber, Wouter Dewulf, António Guterres, Alain Berset, Tufan Erhürman, Maciej Berestecki, Siobhan McGarry and more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Week Ender Podcast: Sarah talks to Zia Weise, Marianne Gros and Agnes Rønberg about the contradictions in the EU's approach to wildfires.

DRIVING THE DAY

WELCOME TO THE BUNKER: As wildfires tear across southern Europe, officials in a control room filled with screens and computers are matching requests for planes, crews and equipment with whatever help is available. The system runs on speed, coordination and a fair bit of improvisation — but can it keep

pace as crisis becomes the norm?

The Commission's Emergency Response Coordination Center, hidden a few minutes' walk from POLITICO HQ, looks the part: walls of screens, rows of desks, ringing phones and duty officers watching disasters unfold in real time. When Playbook visited, one official was flicking between X, Greek news sites and fire maps as the latest blazes spread.

What it actually does: The center is not an EU fire brigade and does not replace national emergency services. Countries remain in command on their own territory. When one is overwhelmed, it can ask Brussels for help; the center then circulates the request, matches it with offers from other governments, coordinates transport and deployments, and can draw on the EU-funded rescEU reserve of planes and equipment.

The promise: "No request goes unanswered," deputy head of unit Borja Miguelez told Playbook. But that doesn't always mean the requested item is sitting ready in a Brussels warehouse — often, the job is finding another way.

Casting the net wider: Ukraine's civil protection authority recently asked for protective netting to shield firefighting vehicles from drone attacks. DG ECHO — the Commission department responsible for civil protection, which houses the crisis unit — had none. The Commission's fisheries department, however, had illegal fishing nets confiscated from France and Italy. They were sent to Ukraine instead.

Running lean: The center relies on 24 duty officers working 12-hour rotations, with a minimum of three present during the day and two overnight, ensuring a "continuous presence," unit head Maria Zuber said. During major emergencies, colleagues are pulled in from elsewhere in the roughly 60-person unit.

Brussels quietly beefed up: DG ECHO secured extra civil-protection posts in an internal Commission staffing reshuffle first revealed by Playbook earlier this year. But experience can't be added overnight. "It takes about two years to really train someone so that, if there's an earthquake in Turkey in the middle of the night, they know exactly what to do," Zuber said.

Built for the new normal? The mechanism has handled more than 860 requests since its creation in 2001, expanding from earthquakes and storms to pandemics, war, evacuations and increasingly frequent wildfires. Its staff are skilled at stretching resources and improvising — but creativity can only go so far when a system built for occasional emergencies is operating in permanent crisis mode.

BIG AND BREAKING

WHILE YOU WERE SLEEPING: Donald Trump announced on Truth Social that his Board of Peace has struck a deal to disarm Hamas and other armed groups in Gaza, calling it a "monumental step toward lasting PEACE and SECURITY." My U.S. colleagues have more details .

MEET BRUSSELS' NEW AI WATCHDOGS: Beginning Sunday, a 37-person Commission team will get sweeping new powers to police the world's biggest AI companies.

THE €30 BILLION AI BET: The EU has launched plans to build seven massive AI data centers , with backing from Germany, Italy, Spain, Portugal and Greece.

CLIMATE DEBATE HEATS UP: With flames raging across southern Europe, Britain, France and Spain are using the moment to make the case for stronger climate action , per POLITICO's Zia Weise. Zia also reports that researchers estimate that climate change made the extreme weather behind Spain's

devastating wildfires around 20 times more likely .

THE CHINA DILEMMA: Three years on, the EU's Foreign Subsidies Regulation is changing how Chinese companies do business in Europe — but whether Europe is better off is another question .

FIFA'S EUROPE PROBLEM

EUROPE TAKES ON FIFA: European football authorities' decision to boycott the World Cup if FIFA pushes ahead with its plan to sell a stake in its commercial operations to investors "is not a football story," Council of Europe Secretary-General Alain Berset told Playbook. "It is a story about rules. Who writes them. Whether they are applied. And who may change them."

Breaking ranks: The Council of Europe has historically worked closely with world football's governing body, even signing a cooperation agreement in 2018 . Berset insists the institution remains committed to the partnership, but says the 2026 tournament exposed governance problems that can't be ignored, from Folarin Balogun's overturned suspension to racist abuse of players.

"Football does not need a shareholder. It needs rules," Berset said. Europe has repeatedly responded to sporting scandals by writing new rules — from the Heysel stadium disaster , which led to a Council of Europe convention on spectator safety, to anti-doping rules that now bind more than 50 countries — and he argues stronger laws can protect the World Cup.

Next up: Berset wants to launch talks on an integrity framework for the 2030 World Cup when European sports ministers meet in Monaco on Nov. 3-4.

JUST AS PLAYBOOK WAS GOING TO PIXEL ... FIFA issued a press release saying it "respects" the critics of its privatization plan but will push ahead with a consultation. "Our planned consultation process was disrupted by incorrect media reports. We will proceed with this consultation process to ensure that each [member association] has the ability to express its vote based on facts," it said.

SEPP BLATTER HAS VIEWS: Yes, that Sepp Blatter. Gianni Infantino's predecessor told POLITICO's Jonas Loesel he "completely supports the initiative of UEFA" in threatening to boycott the next World Cup if FIFA proceeds with the commercial rights sale. Blatter, whose own presidency ended in scandal, is emerging as the George W. Bush to Infantino's Donald Trump, as Paul Dallison writes in this week's Declassified column .

MEANWHILE, IN BRUSSELS ... Sports Commissioner Glenn Micallef suggested this week that FIFA's plans could even raise questions under EU competition laws — but there's no sign yet the Commission is looking into it. "The Commission is constantly monitoring the functioning of markets," spokesperson Siobhan McGarry said.

Competition lawyers told POLITICO's Francesca Micheletti they don't see an obvious abuse-of-dominance or cartel theory based on what's publicly known.

CYPRUS MISSION

FITTO'S ROCKY START IN CYPRUS: Turkish Cypriot authorities rejected Raffaele Fitto's role as the European Commission's special representative for Cyprus, saying in a statement Thursday that they won't recognize the Commission executive vice president as an interlocutor or accept any official

activities he seeks to conduct in the north.

Fitto arrived in Cyprus last night following U.N. chief António Guterres' visit to the divided island. According to his calendar, Fitto is scheduled to meet President Nikos Christodoulides and Turkish Cypriot leader Tufan Erhürman today, though it's unclear whether the latter will go ahead given the tenor of the statement. Contacted by Playbook last night, the Commission said there were no changes to Fitto's plans.

The foreign ministry for the breakaway Turkish-Cypriot north of Cyprus said Fitto's appointment was made at the request of the Greek Cypriot side without its consent and therefore "carries no legitimacy."

Fitto's mission: Before the Turkish side posted the statement to social media, the Commission on Thursday said the EU remains "firmly committed" to reunifying Cyprus in line with U.N. and EU principles and laws. Commission spokesperson Maciej Berestecki said Fitto would work with Guterres, his Cyprus envoy María Ángela Holguín and other stakeholders to "prepare the ground for the resumption of negotiations."

Why now: The U.N. is trying to restart peace talks that have been stalled since 2017, beginning with confidence-building measures and preparations for a possible meeting of all sides later this year. Fitto's visit follows Guterres' two-day trip, during which the U.N. secretary-general said regional turmoil and shifting geopolitics made resolving the Cyprus conflict more urgent.

6 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

PHARMA D-DAY: Donald Trump's 100 percent tariffs on pharmaceutical imports kick in today. (Morning Health breaks down for subscribers who's in the firing line.)

TUSK'S WARNING: Poland says "everything indicates" that a Russian cruise missile struck its territory, leaving a 10-meter crater near the Ukrainian border.

THE COST OF STRATEGIC AUTONOMY: Europe will need to invest €14 trillion by 2035 to stand on its own economically, technologically and militarily, Bloomberg Intelligence estimates.

PUTIN'S OLYMPIC PRIZE: Russia is back in the Olympic movement — but the Kremlin's victory comes with strings attached, Daria Zakharova reports.

EUROPE'S SPIES, RANKED: L'Express asked 60 intelligence insiders to rank Europe's spy agencies — Britain's MI6 takes gold, France silver and the Netherlands bronze.

FRUIT OF THE OMNIBUS: Honduran melons, American cranberries and South African grapes could all get pricier under the Commission's pesticide omnibus, per my colleague Ketrin Johecová. (More in Morning Agri for subscribers).

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BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Partly cloudy, with a chance of afternoon showers. High 27C.

WHERE WILL CHARLEROI PASSENGERS GO? When Charleroi Airport shuts from Aug. 15 to Oct. 31, 2028, airlines will have to find temporary homes for tens of thousands of passengers. My colleague Tommaso Lecca has been ringing around to see where they might end up. The options are:

Brussels Airport: The obvious answer — but only up to a point. Zaventem could take some strategically important or profitable routes, said Wouter Dewulf, an air transport economist at the University of Antwerp. But it can't swallow Charleroi's entire operation while keeping the same bargain-basement fares. Slots, terminal space, aircraft parking, ground handling and security would all be tight.

Also in Belgium: Ostend might be less attractive to Charleroi passengers because of its location, while Antwerp faces runway, terminal and operational constraints, Dewulf said. Liège is technically possible, but it's primarily a cargo airport and not set up for a sudden passenger influx.

Elsewhere: Lille is probably the most likely alternative, with other possibilities including Luxembourg, Maastricht Aachen, Eindhoven, Weeze, Cologne-Bonn and Paris-Beauvais. But none of these can replicate Charleroi's low costs, large catchment area and extensive low-cost network, Dewulf said. Airlines will likely have to stitch together a patchwork of alternatives, cut frequencies and suspend some routes.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Germany's politicians look forward to a summer break before an autumn that could make or break Friedrich Merz's premiership.

London: Andy Burnham will today announce plans to hand over more money and power to regional mayors.

Paris: France's top constitutional authority will work overtime in August to issue a string of rulings that could derail parts of Emmanuel Macron's agenda.

Washington PM: Donald Trump is locked in a game of chicken with Republican holdouts over his pick for attorney general.

AGENDA

— The ECB releases euro-area bank interest rate statistics for June at 10 a.m.

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Pilar del Castillo Vera; German politician Sven Schulze; EEAS' Vanessa Mock; Katch & Reyners' Zoé Reyners; Agence Tact's Alice Mérel; AP's Elena Becatoros; journalist Andrew Marr; author J.K. Rowling.

Celebrating Saturday: Former MEPs Pedro Marques, Ljudmila Novak, Frances Fitzgerald and Dominique Bilde; Northern Ireland Executive's Nuala McNamee. Swiss National Day.

Celebrating Sunday: POLITICO's Leyla Aksu; former MEPs Robert Roos and John Bowis; Henk Swarttouw, president of the European Cyclists' Federation; David Earnshaw, of Boldt BPI. European Roma Holocaust Memorial Day.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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